

So and so that

Teaching guide

Distinguish a result from an intended purpose.

Understand the distinction

So commonly introduces a result: I was tired, so I went home. So that commonly introduces a purpose, often with can, could, will, or would: I wrote it down so that I could remember it.

That is sometimes omitted in informal purpose clauses: I wrote it down so I could remember. Use context to decide the meaning. In order to takes a base verb; in order that takes a clause and is more formal. A purpose does not guarantee success.

Compare the patterns

RESULT

The train stopped, so we got off.

Getting off followed the stop.

PURPOSE

I left early so that I could find a seat.

Finding a seat was the goal.

INFINITIVE

I left early in order to find a seat.

The same purpose uses to + verb.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Result or purpose: I spoke slowly so that everyone could follow?

2. Correct this: I called in order to that I could ask.

3. Does left early so that I could get a seat prove I got one?

Use it in your own life

Write a purpose sentence and a separate sentence giving the actual result.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. Purpose.

The speaker intended to help understanding.

2. I called so that I could ask.

Alternatively: I called in order to ask.

3. No. It states a purpose.

The intended result may not have happened.

One possible response

I left early so that I could catch the bus. It was full, so I waited for the next one.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-30.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write a purpose sentence and a separate sentence giving the actual result.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.